

International Conference
“MYSTICISM and SUFISM: An Opportunity for Expanding Cultural
Interactions and Strengthening Cooperation”
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A B S T R A C T

The mobility of population is as old as the history of humanity itself. The states and nations in the past have always had to confront the problems arising from the diversity of groups within one polity. Military conquests and subsequent territorial expansions were the ways most familiar during the times of empires through which ethnic groups had spread their cultural influence. Military conquest by an ethnic group did not, however, necessarily mean that the cultural outlook of the conqueror is to inevitably impose itself on the other. At the end of the 19th Century, despite the appearance of a unified British culture and a strong sense of British identity, fueled by the successful pursuit of a colonial empire overseas and the consolidation of the industrial revolution at home, there were clearly differences in the ways in which the population of the country experienced that Britishness and felt themselves part of the nation. In this scenario, President Muhammad Khatami of Iran has given a concept of ‘Dialogue among Civilizations’ countering the Western concept of ‘Clash of Civilizations’ put forward by the American scholar, Samuel Huntington. Mr. Khatami’s emphasis reflects on how Iran can interact effectively with the wider world as Iran is an ancient civilization which has benefitted from Islamic civilization and subsequently engaged with Western Civilization.

Sufism is the name given to the mystical movement within Islam. A *Sufi* is a Muslim who dedicates himself to the quest after mystical union (or, better said, reunion) with his Creator. Mystical awareness was certainly present in the Prophet Muhammad’s (Peace be Upon Him) attitude to *Allah* and “mystical” is an entirely appropriate adjective to describe his many experiences of a supernatural presence making contact through him with a new message to mankind. The basis of *Sufism* is the purification of the “heart” and safeguarding it from any affliction and that its end product is the correct and harmonious relationship between man and his Creator. The mystic is not someone whose very person disappears. He or she retains the same character, history, even the same brilliance and everything that makes the person unique and loveable. Hence, Mysticism and *Sufism* provides an opportunity for expanding cultural interactions and strengthening cooperation among peoples and nations of the world.

